Siya Chhibber - Journalism Portfolio

Four Stories on a Crisis

Junior Journalist Program
April to July 2026

THE NEWSROOM

Junior Journalist Program is a paid four-month reporting internship for Alameda County high school students. In my cohort, roughly 90 students applied for 30 positions. Reporters pitch their own stories in weekly editorial meetings, develop them with an assigned advisor, and revise through editorial review before publication.

MY ROLE

Reporter and sole author on all four pieces. I pitched each story, conducted research and source verification, secured and conducted the expert interview, and revised under editorial review before publication.

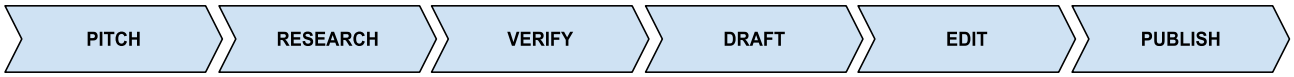
THE BRIEF

Make the opioid crisis understandable to other young people: accurate enough to survive scrutiny, clear enough that a teenager finishes the piece.

METHODS

Story pitching and editorial development; primary and secondary source research; peer-reviewed source verification; expert interviewing; policy analysis; revision; writing for a general audience.

MY PROCESS



The Articles

Four published pieces, each built around a different way of finding and testing a story.
Published in Pleasanton Weekly, Livermore Vine and DanvilleSanRamon.com
Full text of "Beyond 'Just Say No'" follows on pages 2 and 3.

BEHAVIORAL SCIENCE

Changing habits to break addiction

April 14, 2026

Opened with David Sedaris quitting smoking after moving to Japan, then used behavioral research to examine how environment and cue disruption shape habit formation - and why willpower alone is a poor model for dependence.

Reporting challenge: translate mechanism into something a reader feels rather than studies.

CASE STUDY

Belief systems and opioid addiction

April 21, 2026

Examined how personal conviction intersected with medical decisions in the cases of Steve Jobs and Prince. I rebuilt the piece around independently sourced events and revised the framing to separate evidence from blame.

Reporting challenge: describe a causal sequence without indicting a faith.

EXPERT INTERVIEW

The depiction of addiction in cinema

July 12, 2026

An eight-question Q&A with Antonio Alfaro, who teaches film studies at Las Positas College, on portrayals of substance use from Reefer Madness to Euphoria, including glamorization, realism, narrative structure, and social responsibility.

Reporting challenge: the strongest answers came from asking about specific films, not the topic in general.

POLICY ARGUMENT

Beyond 'Just Say No'

July 27, 2026

Argued that evidence-based prevention should replace dated scare tactics, drawing on an APA longitudinal study, a Surgeon General designation, and a GAO report.

Reporting challenge: criticism only held if the evidence was stronger than readers' familiarity with the program.

Beyond 'Just Say No' - Pleasanton Weekly

pleasantonweekly.com/alameda-county/2026/07/27/beyond-just-say-no

Contributing writer July 27, 2026

By Siya Chhibber

For decades, the standard approach to youth drug education in American schools could be summed up in three words: “Just Say No.” Programs like Drug Abuse Resistance Education (D.A.R.E.), an abstinence only program founded in 1983, became staples in elementary and middle school classrooms across the country. Clad in iconic black T-shirts, local police officers lectured students on the legal and physical dangers of illicit substances, aiming to build a shield of absolute abstinence.

However, a massive body of public health research and behavioral science reveals an unexpected truth: The traditional, zero-tolerance lecture model simply doesn’t work. To effectively protect teenagers, educational frameworks must pivot toward realistic, evidence-based strategies that prioritize honest dialogue over scare tactics and taboo-building.

While traditional abstinence-only programs were immensely popular with school administrators and politicians, their real-world impact on youth substance use was negligible. A landmark 10-year longitudinal study published by the American Psychological Association (APA) followed students who underwent the traditional D.A.R.E. curriculum. The researchers found no statistically significant difference in drug use, attitudes toward drugs, or self-esteem between D.A.R.E. graduates and peers who had received standard health education.

This lack of efficacy caught the attention of federal oversight agencies. In 2001, the U.S. Surgeon General formally categorized the classic D.A.R.E. program as an “Ineffective Primary Prevention Program”. This finding was further supported by a 2003 report from the U.S. General Accounting Office (GAO), which concluded that there were no significant differences in illicit drug use between students who participated in the program and those who didn’t.

Behavioral scientists point to several structural flaws that doomed the original “Just Say No” model. First, the program relied heavily on hyperbole and fear mongering messaging. When teenagers inevitably realized that some of the dangers of certain

substances were exaggerated, they began to dismiss legitimate information about the relative harms of much more dangerous drugs.

Second, the traditional model operated under the assumption that a top-down lecture could entirely override the complex social realities of adolescence. By framing substance use strictly as a moral or legal failing rather than a public health issue influenced by mental health, environment, and social dynamics, the program created a cultural taboo. Essentially, the zero-tolerance approaches often push youth into secrecy, making them less likely to communicate openly with trusted adults or ask critical questions when they encounter peer pressure or high-risk situations.

In response to decades of criticism, modern prevention science has shifted. Even the national D.A.R.E. curriculum eventually phased out its original lecture-heavy format, adopting newer, more interactive models like "Keepin' it REAL." Modern prevention science demonstrates that effective programs must focus on real-world decision-making, peer-led communication and building genuine socio-emotional skills, rather than just delivering a list of strict prohibitions.

For student journalists and school boards evaluating local health curricula, the message from the scientific community is clear – good intentions do not guarantee good outcomes. For an anti-drug campaign to truly protect youth, it must respect the intelligence of its audience, rely on objective facts, and provide practical, evidence-based tools to navigate high-pressure environments.

This article was written as part of a program to educate youth and others about Alameda County's opioid crisis, prevention and treatment options. The program is funded by the Alameda County Behavioral Health Department and the grant is administered by Three Valleys Community Foundation.